

Chapter 144-3

Xu Qingzhu still remembered that rainy day. She was walking back to the dorm from the library with an umbrella when she happened to see Lin Luoxi and her girlfriend at the sports field. She was still hesitating whether to greet them when she heard that girl say guiltily to Lin Luoxi: "I shouldn't have wasted your time."

Lin Luoxi responded coldly: "Oh."

There wasn't much dialogue. Lin Luoxi called out to Xu Qingzhu: "Little Zhuzi, give me a ride back."

At that time, she and Lin Luoxi lived in the same dormitory building.

Though not on the same floor.

When they came back, they happened to see Sally standing in the rain downstairs with an umbrella, holding a bouquet of roses.

A blonde, blue-eyed girl, expressing her feelings passionately and sincerely.

This was what Sally said to Lin Luoxi at the time: "I know you have a girlfriend, and I'm not trying to break you up. But today is your birthday, so let me, an admirer, give you a bouquet of flowers. Happy birthday."

Her Chinese wasn't fluent, and when she said this, it was a mix of Chinese and English.

Her tone was particularly amusing.

But no one laughed.

Sally said: "A girl as pretty as you—how can you not have flowers on your birthday?"

Lin Luoxi accepted them, of course, and went into the dormitory building with Xu Qingzhu without much expression.

But while waiting for the elevator, Lin Luoxi quickly walked back out.

Sally happened to still be standing at the entrance, seemingly lost in thought.

Lin Luoxi called out to her: "Hey."

Sally was startled: "Are you calling me?"

Lin Luoxi nodded: "Yeah, you."

Sally: "...What is it?"

"Want to go hiking tomorrow?" Lin Luoxi said: "I just broke up."

Sally was someone who was particularly good at seizing opportunities, so she accepted the olive branch Lin Luoxi extended without hesitation.

Then they dated all the way until graduation.

It wasn't until graduation that Sally hid the fact that she was returning to her home country. She and Lin Luoxi had a huge argument, and only then did the two of them separate.

Xu Qingzhu remembered that she had asked Lin Luoxi at the time: "Do you really like her? Aren't you worried she's a player?"¹

Lin Luoxi told her with great nonchalance: "Youth only lasts a few years. You have to date a few people for it not to be a waste."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Even the hiking trip the next day, Xu Qingzhu had accompanied Lin Luoxi. Bai Weiwei also went along.

Back then, Bai Weiwei rather looked down on Sally, always thinking that Sally was after Lin Luoxi's family connections.

But Xu Qingzhu felt that Sally wasn't scheming at all, and they had been on good terms all the way until now.

As it turned out, she hadn't misjudged people.

The only one she had misjudged was Bai Weiwei.

Back then, Lin Luoxi had also tried to set her up with another girl from the hiking club. She was very good-looking, with a heroic kind of appearance. She always liked wearing white shirts with black pants, paired with white sneakers. She was from the computer science department, and apparently her family was well-off too.

She just wasn't very good at talking. When eating with Xu Qingzhu, the conversation would easily run dry. But she was very obedient and hardworking. Once, Xu Qingzhu's roommate's computer broke down in the middle of the night and she urgently needed to process some files. Xu Qingzhu had no choice but to ask for her help.

The result was that she ran a kilometer from the east side of campus to their dormitory building to fix her roommate's computer.

It's just that there was no spark between Xu Qingzhu and her.

According to Lin Luoxi, that girl actually quite liked her—it was just that Xu Qingzhu showed no reaction at all.

Someone who doesn't receive a response will naturally cool down.

That girl got married last year and even posted about it on social media.

Xu Qingzhu sent her a gift.²

This was the closest she had come to romance in her unremarkable student days.

Later, when she met Liang Shi and said she was getting married, everyone was shocked.

Lin Luoxi was quite surprised: "Other than being a bit richer than Xiao Wu, what else about this person can compare to Xiao Wu?"

Xiao Wu was the girl Lin Luoxi had introduced to her back then.

Xu Qingzhu smiled: "You have to spend time with someone before you can judge, right? I like her."

At the time, she had only said that based on their childhood friendship, and also so that everyone wouldn't worry.

But later, during their daily interactions, Xu Qingzhu silently agreed with Lin Luoxi's words countless times.

That person really couldn't compare to Xiao Wu in any way.

But at that time, Xu Qingzhu's heart was already dead.

How should she describe her state of mind back then?

It was like a flower that bloomed joyfully before its season, only to find it couldn't adapt to the cold weather, withering and dying prematurely.

Meeting Liang Shi again was probably like living toward death.³

So she had been far too careful.

Before, she thought she had everything under control. After going through all those things, her heart could no longer be the same as when she had just reunited with Liang Shi.

Yet she never expected... that was only the beginning.

Afterward, she fell deeper step by step, sinking further step by step.

But she felt that Liang Shi was like a castle in the air—beautiful as a dream, as an illusion.

She couldn't hold onto her.

Footnotes:

¹ **Player** (海王): Literally "Sea King," this is Chinese internet slang for someone who dates or flirts with multiple people at once, similar to a "player" or someone who "has many fish in the sea." The term implies someone who keeps many romantic interests on the hook simultaneously.

² **Sent her a gift** (随了個份子): In Chinese culture, "随份子" refers to giving a monetary gift (usually in a red envelope) for occasions like weddings, births, or funerals. It's a social custom where the amount given often depends on your relationship with the person and is sometimes seen as an obligation within social circles.

³ **Living toward death** (向死而生): A philosophical concept originating from Martin Heidegger's existentialist philosophy, meaning to live authentically by confronting and accepting one's mortality. In this context, it suggests that Xu Qingzhu, whose heart had "died," found new life/purpose through meeting Liang Shi again—being reborn from a state of emotional death.